

CDN Incident Alert: 0066. TLP: CLEAR			Date
Title	PL	Macron, Merz and Starmer Cocaine Use Claim	14/05/2025

Summary

- Ahead of Polish elections, Russia-aligned actors in Poland were amplifying a video alleging cocaine use by three European leaders on their way to Ukraine.
- The posts alleging the leaders' drug use spun the video as proof of the West's moral decay, starting with its rulers, and as evidence that Ukraine, headed by a drug addict, is a menace.
- The claim went viral, endorsed by leading Russian officials, e.g. [Maria Zakharova](#) (326.2K views of the post) and propaganda mouthpieces ([Soloviev Live](#), 200.2K views). 1.47K posts by Polish-language or Poland-based accounts, including known [pro-Kremlin actors](#), reposted or discussed the video on X and Facebook alone.
- Pro-Kremlin actors seized on the leaders' Kyiv visit to recycle long-running "drug-addict" tropes, misframing a tissue and coffee stirrer as cocaine paraphernalia and amplifying the smear to depict European and Ukrainian officials as morally corrupt.
- Advocate for the removal of false content and amplification networks from platforms, while raising awareness among media and targeted organizations.

Incident – When, Who, did what, to say what, to whom, why?

On May 10, 2025, viral social media posts and Russian officials alleged that French President Emmanuel Macron, German Chancellor Friedrich Merz, and UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer were caught using cocaine on a train to Kyiv, Ukraine. The claims centered on a video showing the leaders together, where a white object near Macron's glass was speculated to be a bag of cocaine, and an object near Merz's hand was described as a snuff spoon. The claim was spread and amplified by the far-right, conspiracy-linked [accounts](#), Kremlin [officials](#) and [Telegram channels](#) that are a part of the Russian disinformation and propaganda ecosystem. The claim was used by Russia-linked actors in the Polish social media ecosystem, a week ahead of the Polish presidential elections. These included Piotr Panasiuk, a well-known Moscow-aligned pundit [accused of espionage](#) and being an [accomplice](#) of Russia's crimes against Ukraine and its citizens, as well as a suspected agent or employee of the Russian special services. Panasiuk [shared](#) a post by [Anatoliy Shariy](#), a pro-Putin blogger [wanted by Ukrainian authorities](#) for treason, alleging the three European leaders and Zelensky were involved in drug use, [adding](#) that Ukraine's security services also blackmail Polish politicians with such scandals in other of his posts sharing the video. In addition, Zakharova's post alleging the same was reposted and translated by the Telegram channel [Pożyteczne Śmigło](#), which repeatedly amplifies content from overt Kremlin outlets (e.g., RT) and known proxy brands such as InfoDefensePOLAND, indicating it functions as a relay node within the Russian-disinformation ecosystem.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Western democracies are collapsing morally and socially ; Europe is run by external puppet-masters ; Ukraine's leadership is morally degenerate and illegitimate

Sub-narratives: Western leaders are morally degraded and inept ; European politicians are secretly controlled by Ukrainian intelligence ; Zelensky is a drug addict

Impact

Across the Polish pro-disinformation accounts we monitor, the posts with the claim have logged roughly 90k views, 8k likes, 71 shares, and 14 comments to date (figures still updating).

The incident was widely recognized as a Russian disinformation effort. It was used to target EU and Polish politicians a week ahead of Polish presidential elections.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0066: Degrade Adversary](#) – Drug-use allegations aimed at European and Ukrainian leaders.

[T0118: Amplify Existing Narrative](#) – The Kremlin has long promoted the tropes that Zelensky is a drug addict and Europe is in moral decay.

[T0023: Distort facts](#) – Misrepresented a tissue and coffee stirrer as a "cocaine bag" and "snuff spoon" in the video.

[T0068: Respond to Breaking News Event or Active Crisis](#) – Exploited the leaders’ high-profile Kyiv trip to launch the rumor.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Continued monitoring of activity targeting Polish elections.

Recommendations: Insist on platforms taking down false content and coordinated networks involved in its amplification. Raise awareness with media and other organisations targeted by the campaign.

Repo rt	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
N/A	Russia/Russia-aligned	Upon request	Pavlo Kryvenko and Laima Venclauskienė, Debunk.org	Facebook, X, Telegram	